Two Decades of the International Industrial Organization Conference: A Descriptive Analysis

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Abstract

I construct a comprehensive dataset of 6,289 presentations across 20 editions of the International Industrial Organization Conference (IIOC) between 2006 and 2026 and match them to the OpenAlex bibliometric database to track which papers reach journals and where. Several patterns stand out. The conference has become smaller, falling from 400 to roughly 260 papers per year, but also more selective, more institutionally concentrated, and more senior. The Herfindahl-Hirschman Index of presenting-institution concentration has nearly doubled, and the share of presentations from RePEc top-20 departments has risen from 16% to 25%. The median presenter's years of publishing experience has roughly doubled, from 6 years in 2006 to 13 years in 2026. European representation has declined from 21% to 16% while the Asia-Pacific share has more than doubled to 12%. About 40% of papers from mature cohorts are verifiably published in peer-reviewed journals, and the share landing in top-5 general-interest journals has nearly tripled. Rising Star sessions feature a notably higher female share (28% versus 21%) but similar publication outcomes. A formal test of whether discussant quality predicts publication success yields a precise null.

1 Introduction

Academic conferences serve as the primary marketplace for new research ideas. Working papers are presented, discussed, refined, and, with luck and perseverance, eventually published.

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Despite their centrality to the research production process, we know relatively little about the systematic patterns of who presents at conferences, where they come from, what happens to the papers afterward, and how these patterns evolve over time. Field conferences in particular occupy a curious middle ground: large enough to be a meaningful selection event but small enough that idiosyncratic choices by organizers, discussants, and chairs shape participation in visible ways.

A small but growing literature has begun to study conferences as objects of inquiry. Gorodnichenko et al. (2021) analyze papers presented at the AEA, EEA, and RES annual meetings and find that presenting at a major conference raises the probability of publishing in a top-tier journal by up to 4.8 percentage points. Spiegel and Toivanen (2022) study five editions of the EARIE conference and document that 40–50% of presented papers remain unpublished years later, with published papers taking on average more than three years to appear. Ellison (2002) and Hamermesh (2013) document that the economics publishing process has slowed and become more concentrated over recent decades, pushing conference output further from final publication and making program-level data an increasingly useful window into current research. On the gender dimension, Chari and Goldsmith-Pinkham (2017) document that women made up about 21% of all authors at the NBER Summer Institute; Hospido and Sanz (2021) and Dupas et al. (2026) find evidence of gender-differentiated evaluation in economics; and Lundberg and Stearns (2019) document that the share of women in the profession has been roughly flat for two decades. The geographic concentration of economics research has been analyzed by Angus et al. (2021), Kocher and Sutter (2001), Cardoso et al. (2010), and Ductor and Visser (2023), with US institutions dominating top journals but European and Asian output growing.

This paper contributes by providing the first longitudinal analysis of a field conference spanning two decades. I examine the International Industrial Organization Conference (IIOC), the premier annual gathering of industrial organization economists in North America. Organized by the Industrial Organization Society since 2003 and held annually (with a COVID cancellation in 2020 and a virtual edition in 2021), the IIOC brings together several hundred researchers each year to present and discuss new work in IO, antitrust, regulation, and related fields.

The IIOC occupies a specific niche in the IO conference landscape. The European Association for Research in Industrial Economics (EARIE), founded in 1974, has long served as the primary IO conference in Europe. More recently, the Asia-Pacific Industrial Organization Conference (APIOC) was established in 2016, filling a similar role for the rapidly growing IO community in the Asia-Pacific region. Together, these three conferences form the regional pillars of the field, and shifts in participation at each speaks to broader changes

in the geography of economic research.

Using programs scraped from Editorial Express and matched against OpenAlex, I document five facts. First, the conference has become smaller and denser: presentations fell by 37% but the drop reflects fewer parallel sessions rather than a shorter schedule. Second, the conference has become more concentrated, both in a broad sense (the HHI of presenting institutions nearly doubled) and specifically at the top: the share of presentations from RePEc top-20 departments rose from 16% to 25%. Third, the typical presenter has become substantially more senior, with median years of publishing experience roughly doubling over the sample. Fourth, geography has shifted: European representation fell from 21% to 16%, while Asia-Pacific rose from 5% to 12%. Fifth, quality has risen in parallel: the share of IIOC papers landing in the top-5 general-interest journals has nearly tripled, even as the overall verified journal publication rate has stayed near 40%.

Taken together, these patterns suggest a conference that has moved upmarket: fewer presentations, from a more concentrated and senior set of institutions and researchers, yielding a rising share of top-journal placements. Whether this reflects deliberate selectivity by the program committee, declining submissions from marginal institutions, or substitution toward EARIE and APIOC, the data cannot fully distinguish. What the data do show is that a formal test of whether discussant quality predicts publication success yields a precise null, offering no support for the hypothesis that getting a "star" discussant improves a paper's prospects.

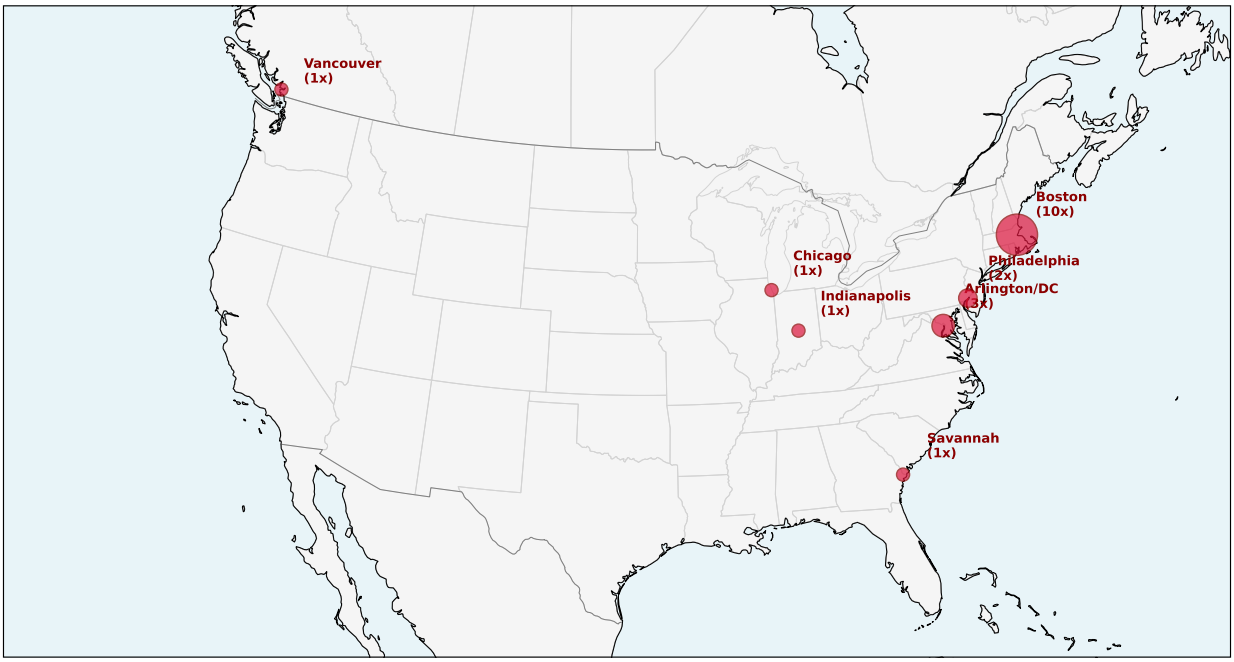
2 Data

2.1 The IIOC and its Audience

The IIOC has been held annually since 2003, with the 2020 Philadelphia edition cancelled due to COVID-19 and a virtual edition held in 2021. The 2020 accepted program was published but never presented; I exclude it from all figures, tables, and trend analyses below because those "presentations" do not correspond to actual conference events. Boston has hosted 10 of the 19 in-person editions; Philadelphia, Arlington, Chicago, Indianapolis, Washington DC, Savannah, and Vancouver have hosted the remainder. Figure 1 plots the geography of host cities; Figure 2 plots the institutional origins of all 2,970 presenters in the analysis sample.

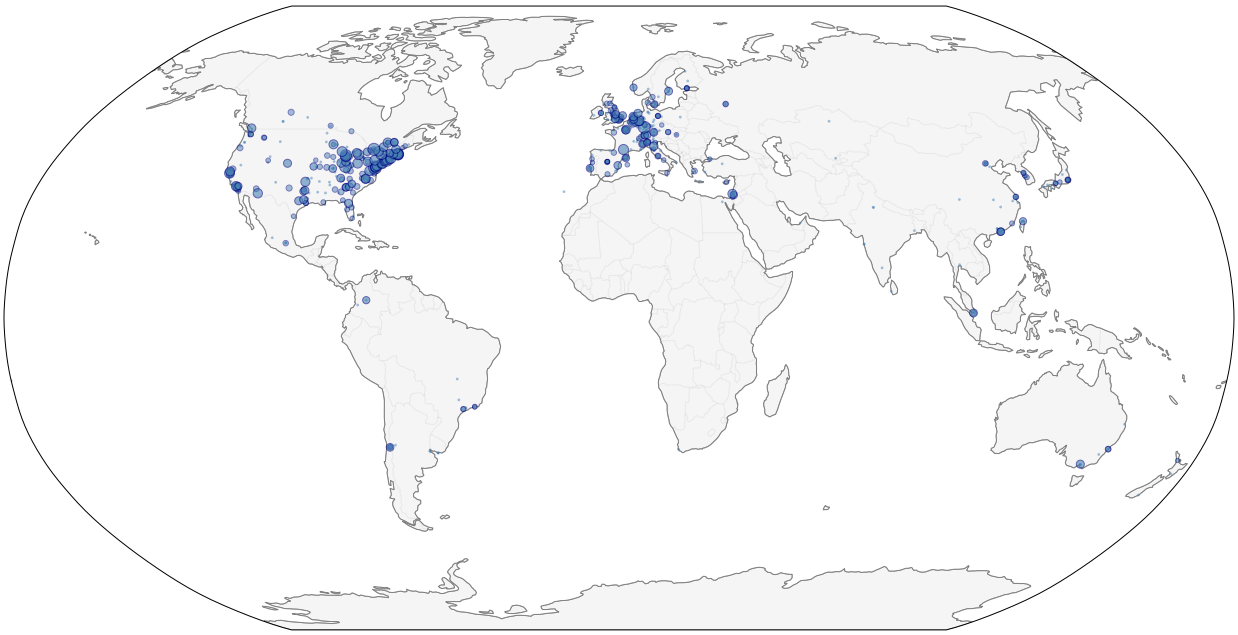
Together, these maps preview the central facts about IIOC participation: the conference is predominantly North American, with a long European tail and a growing Asia-Pacific presence. About 75–80% of presenters in any given year are based at a US or Canadian institution. Tel Aviv University, the University of Melbourne, and a handful of leading

Figure 1: IIOC Host Cities, 2006–2026



Notes: Bubble size is proportional to the number of times each city has hosted the IIOC. Boston has been the dominant host (10 of 19 in-person editions); the conference has otherwise circulated among a small number of US cities and made one visit to Vancouver. The 2020 edition was cancelled due to COVID-19; the 2021 edition was virtual.

Figure 2: Geographic Origin of IIOC Presenters, 2006–2026



Notes: Each bubble is an institution that has sent at least one IIOC presenter; bubble size is proportional to the square root of total presentations across the sample. The US Northeast dominates, with secondary clusters in the Midwest and on the US West Coast. International clusters are visible in the UK, Continental Europe, and East Asia and Australia.

European universities anchor the international representation.

2.2 Data Construction

The IIOC has posted its conference programs on the Editorial Express platform since 2006, following a consistent URL pattern. Each program lists all sessions with their papers, presenting authors, institutional affiliations, session chairs, and discussants. I wrote a Python-based parser to extract structured data from these HTML pages across 21 years of varying formats. The HTML structure changed several times, moving from table-based layouts with explicit metadata fields (2006–2011) to inline headers with block-detail navigation (2012–2026). Format-specific parsing logic is required for each era, and a small number of rows in the 2008–2011 vintages have their paper titles replaced by JEL-codes lines in the original HTML; these are recovered by cross-referencing the adjacent title fields.

The final analysis dataset contains 6,289 paper presentations across 1,707 sessions, involving 2,970 unique presenting authors from 1,563 distinct institutions. (The full raw data, including the 2020 program, cover 6,613 presentations and 3,044 presenters.) I supplement the base data with four enrichments. First, I infer presenter gender from first names us-

ing the `gender-guesser` Python library, which classifies approximately 78% of names; the remaining 22% are coded as unknown, driven primarily by East Asian names and initials. Second, I classify institutions into three regions (North America, Europe, and Asia-Pacific) based on keyword matching. Third, I match presentations against the OpenAlex bibliometric database to track publication outcomes. Fourth, I build citation profiles for presenters and discussants from a locally downloaded snapshot of 22 million OpenAlex economics-related works, which I use to measure both author seniority and the effect of discussant quality on publication.

For the publication matching, I use an author-verified two-stage procedure designed to minimize false positives from title-keyword overlap across unrelated research fields. Stage one joins each IIOC presenter's name against the local OpenAlex snapshot (restricted to the Economics, Business, Social Sciences, and Decision Sciences fields), keeping only works where the presenter (or a coauthor where the IIOC program lists one) actually appears as a listed author. Stage two supplements the local snapshot with a live Crossref query for any IIOC presenter whose papers would otherwise be unmatched; Crossref has better coverage of journal articles published in the past twelve months than the OpenAlex snapshot. In both stages, I then require that the candidate publication's title meet a similarity threshold of 0.82 against the IIOC paper title (a blend of Jaro-Winkler and token-set ratio), and I restrict the publication year to a window of one year before to twelve years after the presentation. Throughout the paper, I distinguish journal publications from working-paper repositories (SSRN, NBER, RePEc, arXiv, Harvard Dataverse, and other preprint venues); all publication rates and the top-outlet ranking in Table 5 refer to peer-reviewed journal publications only. The raw any-match rate of 67% mixes journal publications with working-paper postings, and the National Bureau of Economic Research working paper series alone accounts for several hundred matches that should not be counted as publications.

Table 1 reports summary statistics by year, including the number of presentations, sessions, distinct institutions, the female share among classifiable presenters, the Herfindahl-Hirschman index of institutional concentration, and the journal publication rate for each cohort. These year-level statistics are the building blocks of all the time-series figures that follow. Rates for the most recent cohorts (2022 onward) reflect pipeline papers that are still moving through the review process and should therefore be read as lower bounds.

3 The IIOC Over Time

This section documents how the conference has evolved over the 21 years of the sample. I organize the discussion around four themes: size and format, institutional concentration,

Table 1: Summary Statistics by Year

Year	Papers	Sessions	Presenters	Inst.	% Fem.	% Eur.	% Asia	HHI	% Publ.
2006	365	96	351	251	23.6	19.2	2.7	60	39.5
2007	310	95	286	208	17.5	18.7	2.3	71	37.7
2008	382	105	353	255	19.1	18.1	6.5	60	43.5
2009	400	106	366	258	24.8	22.5	5.8	59	37.8
2010	357	102	328	241	21.9	16.8	7.0	62	40.1
2011	395	106	365	269	21.2	19.0	4.6	54	40.5
2012	347	99	332	250	23.1	19.9	5.5	56	44.1
2013	395	104	366	277	23.9	21.5	5.3	52	44.1
2014	297	81	292	208	21.7	18.2	6.1	81	50.2
2015	259	71	255	177	24.0	16.2	3.9	76	43.6
2016	274	71	269	213	20.9	16.8	6.6	61	43.1
2017	311	84	306	226	18.4	18.6	7.7	67	41.8
2018	291	79	281	194	18.2	10.7	9.6	85	40.5
2019	285	76	269	187	19.1	15.8	7.4	84	45.3
2021	276	73	272	197	18.5	18.1	9.8	69	44.2
2022	260	70	252	166	20.9	20.0	4.2	99	40.4
2023	252	67	248	162	22.0	15.1	4.4	99	27.4
2024	310	82	309	208	20.8	19.0	9.4	75	20.0
2025	268	71	265	170	24.1	13.4	6.3	94	13.4
2026	255	69	252	160	25.9	12.9	12.2	103	12.5

Notes: Papers count all presentations on the program. Inst. is the number of distinct presenting-author institutions. % Fem. is the female share among presenters with classifiable first names. Regional shares are of all presentations. HHI is the Herfindahl-Hirschman index of institutional concentration, multiplied by 10 000. % Publ. counts only peer-reviewed journal publications matched against OpenAlex; working-paper series (NBER, SSRN, RePEc, arXiv, etc.) are excluded. The 2020 conference was cancelled due to COVID-19 but the accepted program was published; the 2022–2026 journal rates reflect pipeline papers still in review.

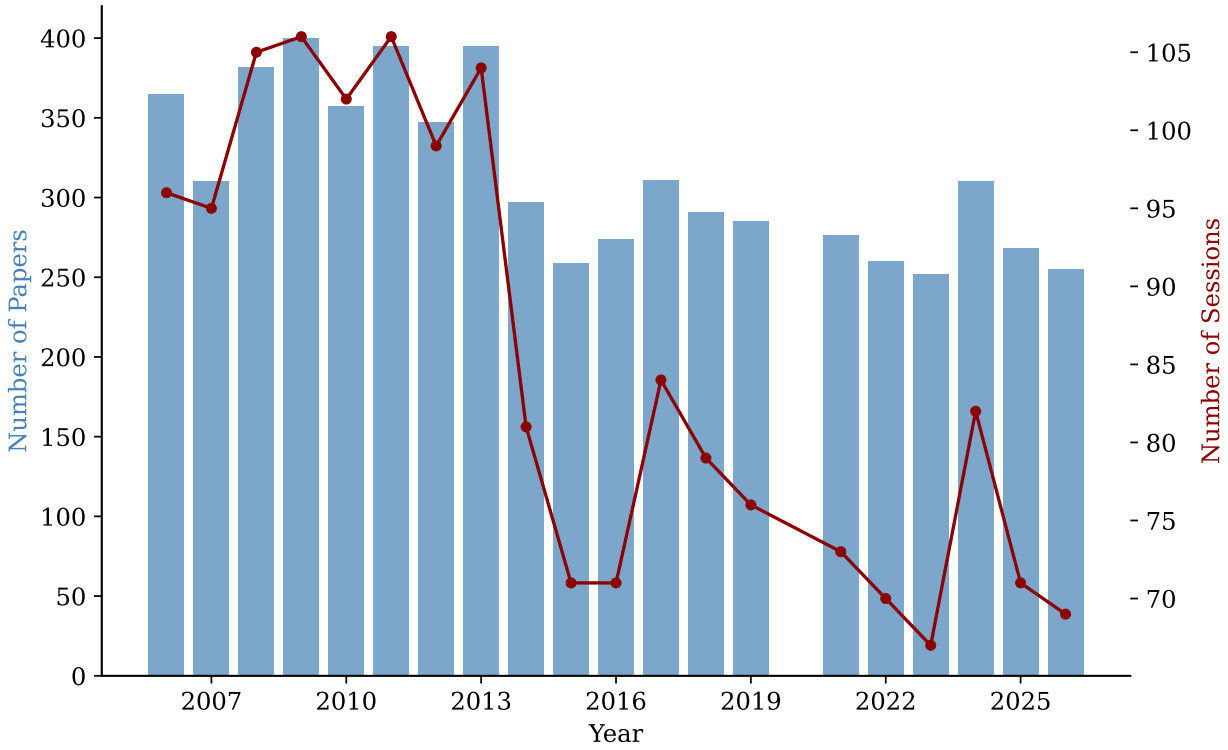
geography and gender, and the seniority of the typical presenter.

3.1 Size and Format

Annual presentations peaked at 400 in 2009 and have fallen to 254 by 2026, a 37% reduction (Figure 3). The number of sessions fell from 106 to 69 over the same period, and the number of distinct presenting institutions declined from 269 to 160. The drop is not explained by a shorter schedule: the conference still runs across roughly the same number of days, and papers per session have hovered around 3.7 throughout the sample. What has contracted is the number of parallel tracks, which has fallen from 14 at the peak to 10 in recent years.

This contraction is not driven by a shorter conference schedule. The number of time slots has remained roughly constant at six or seven per year, and the conference continues to span three days. Rather, the conference has become *narrower*: the average number of parallel sessions running simultaneously in each time slot fell from about 15 in the early years to

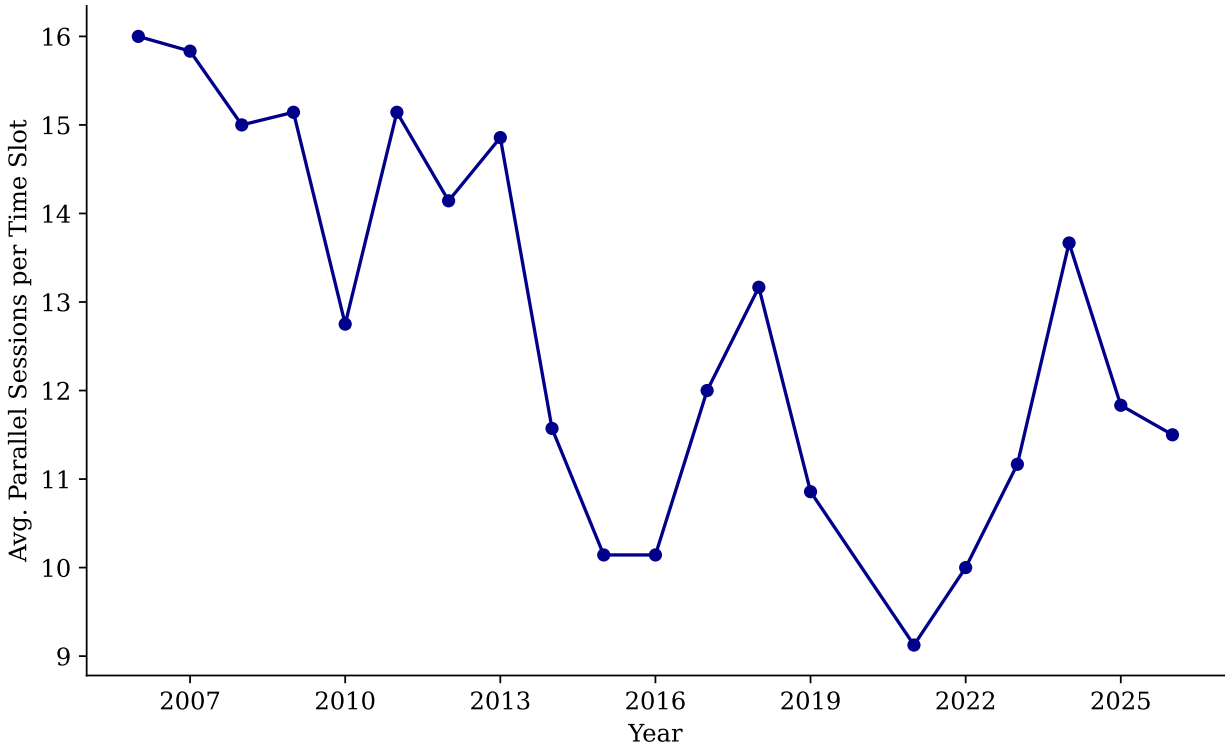
Figure 3: IIOC Conference Size, 2006–2026



Notes: Bars show the number of paper presentations per year (left axis); the line shows the number of sessions per year (right axis). The 2020 conference was cancelled due to COVID-19 and is omitted from this and all subsequent time series.

about 12 in recent years (Figure 4). The IIOC runs the same schedule but in fewer rooms.

Figure 4: Average Number of Parallel Sessions per Time Slot



Notes: For each conference edition, I compute the average number of sessions running simultaneously in each time slot. The decline from approximately 15 to 12 parallel sessions, combined with a roughly stable number of time slots, accounts for most of the drop in total presentations.

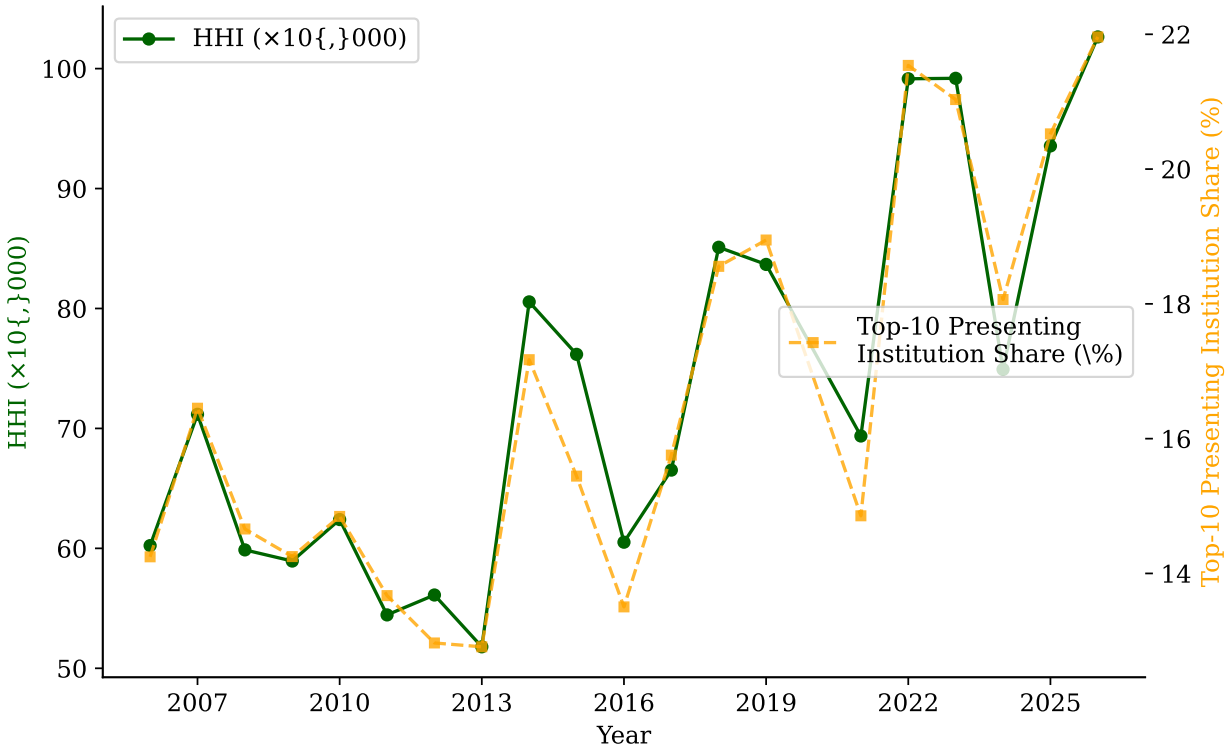
Whether this reflects a deliberate choice to be more selective, declining submissions, or competition from EARIE and APIOC, the data cannot fully distinguish. What they can show, and what the remainder of the section documents, is that the remaining presentations are drawn from a more concentrated, more senior, and higher-placing pool of researchers. That pattern is consistent with greater selectivity rather than declining attractiveness.

3.2 Institutional Concentration

The conference has become more institutionally concentrated over time. The Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (HHI) of presenting-institution concentration has nearly doubled, from about 60 (on a 10,000-point scale) in 2006 to 102 in 2026. Over the same period, the top-10 presenting institution share rose from about 14% to 22% (Figure 5).

These patterns are consistent with the broader evidence on the concentration of top economics output (Kocher and Sutter, 2001; Cardoso et al., 2010; Ductor and Visser, 2023).

Figure 5: Institutional Concentration at IIOC



Notes: The HHI is computed each year from the distribution of presentations across presenting-author institutions and multiplied by 10,000 for readability (left axis). The top-10 presenting institution share is the combined share of presentations from the ten most-represented institutions each year (right axis). Both series move upward, particularly after 2014.

Table 2 lists the 30 most represented institutions over the full sample. Business schools and law schools are rolled up into their parent university, so that, for example, Harvard Business School, Harvard Kennedy School, and Harvard Law School all count toward Harvard University. Presenters who list two institutions joined by "and" (e.g., "Stanford University and Microsoft") contribute to both in the ranking. Research-affiliate networks such as NBER and CEPR are not counted as standalone employers. Harvard leads with 143 presentations across 20 editions, followed by the University of Toronto (125), Indiana University (115), New York University (110), and Northwestern (107). Four US federal and regulatory institutions appear in the top 30, including the Federal Trade Commission (102), the U.S. Department of Justice, and research offices at the Federal Reserve, reflecting the conference's strong ties to antitrust policy.

To test whether the rise in concentration reflects a broader move toward elite departments rather than just a narrow tail of frequent attendees, I classify each presenter's affiliation as belonging to the RePEc top-20 economics departments worldwide or not.[1] Figure 6 plots the share of IIOC presentations from this group over time.

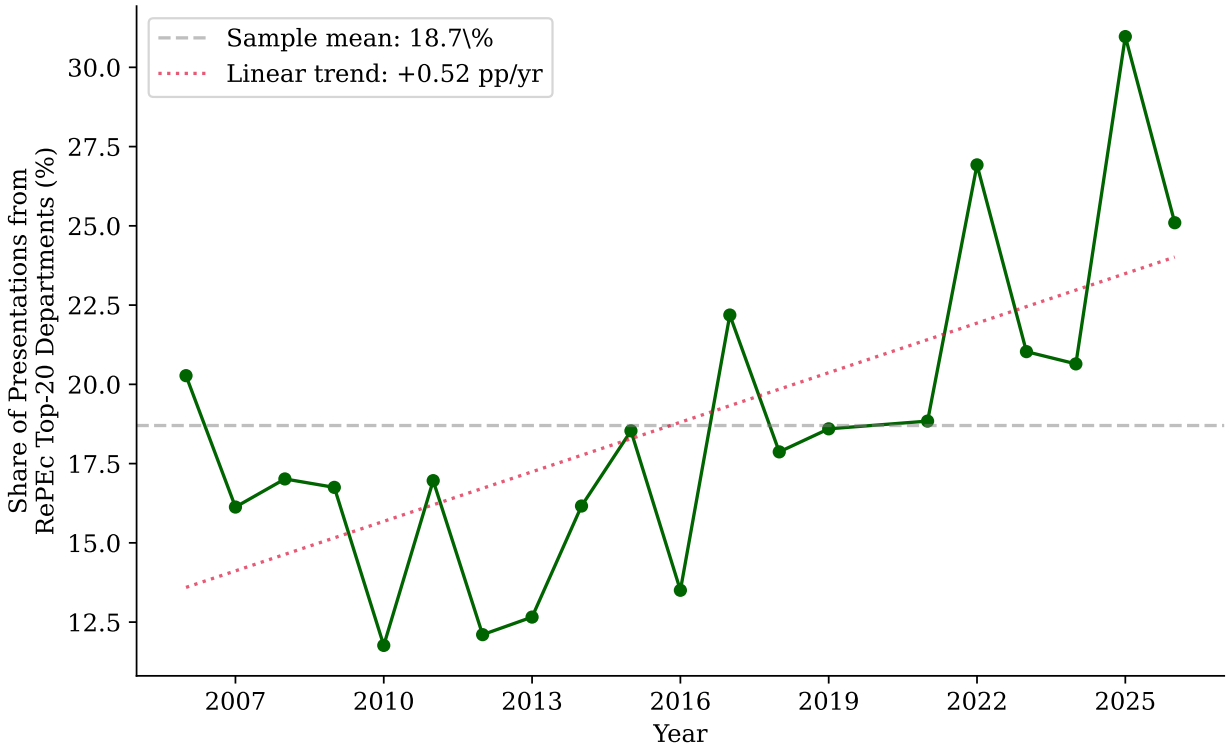
The share has risen from an average of 16.4% in 2006–2010 to 24.9% in 2022–2026, a rise of 8.5 percentage points, or roughly 0.5 percentage points per year. The trend is visible even before the size contraction of the mid-2010s: top-20 departments were already over-represented at the early IIOC, but their share has drifted steadily upward. Two interpretations are consistent with this pattern. Either the program committee has become more selective toward papers from prestigious departments, or researchers at top departments have substituted toward the IIOC as peer field conferences (EARIE, APIOC) have crowded out mid-tier institutions. The data cannot adjudicate between these, but both would be consistent with the parallel rise in top-journal placements documented in Section 4.

3.3 Geography and Gender

Geographically, the IIOC remains a North American conference, with about 75–80% of presenters based at US or Canadian institutions in any given year. Within the remaining share, two trends stand out (Figure 7). European representation has declined steadily, from about 21% in 2006–2010 to 16% in 2022–2026. Over the same period, Asia-Pacific representation has more than doubled, from 5% to 12%. At the current rate of convergence, Asia-Pacific presenters will outnumber Europeans at the IIOC within a few years, a striking

[1] The list is taken from the long-run RePEc department rankings and is intentionally broad: it includes Harvard, MIT, Chicago, Stanford, Yale, Princeton, Berkeley, Columbia, NYU, Northwestern, Michigan, Penn, Duke, Boston University, UCLA, LSE, Oxford, Cambridge, Paris School of Economics, Toulouse, Bocconi, Barcelona School of Economics, and the Pompeu Fabra. Keyword matching against the institution string identifies the affiliation as belonging to a top-20 department; the classifier is intentionally inclusive.

Figure 6: Share of IIOC Presentations from RePEc Top-20 Departments



Notes: An institution is classified as a RePEc top-20 department using keyword matching against the presenting-author institution string. The dashed line is the linear trend over the full sample; the slope of +0.5 percentage points per year is statistically different from zero.

Table 2: Top 30 Presenting Institutions at IIOC, 2006–2026

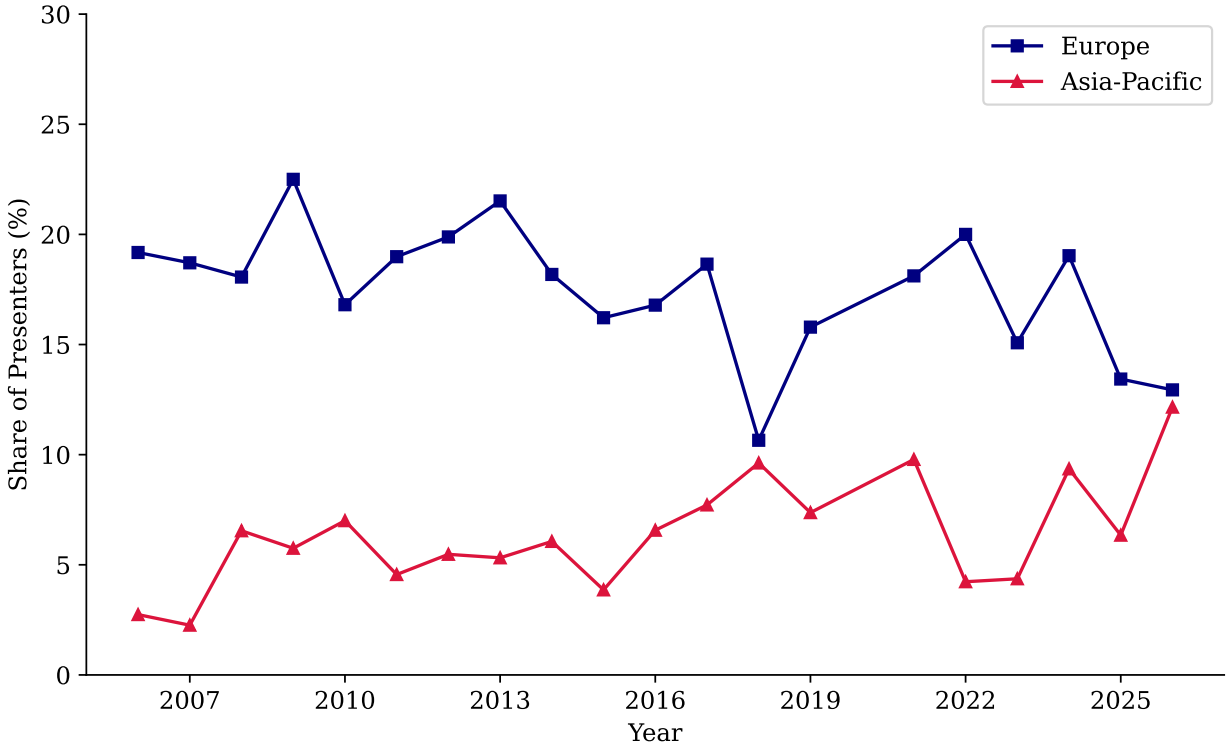
	Institution	Presentations	Distinct Presenters	Years
1	Harvard University	143	91	21
2	University of Toronto	125	52	21
3	Indiana University	115	42	21
4	New York University	110	62	21
5	Northwestern University	107	75	20
6	Boston University	106	57	21
7	Federal Trade Commission	102	44	21
8	Cornell University	99	45	19
9	University of Pennsylvania	90	65	20
10	University of Mannheim	82	50	20
11	MIT	80	50	20
12	University of Maryland	70	30	20
13	University of Chicago	68	50	20
14	Yale University	65	36	17
15	Stanford University	64	50	21
16	University of Michigan	63	35	20
17	KU Leuven	63	40	19
18	Düsseldorf Institute for Competition Economics	61	41	17
19	University of Wisconsin-Madison	59	41	17
20	Toulouse School of Economics	55	45	19
21	Johns Hopkins University	55	26	20
22	University of Rochester	52	22	17
23	Northeastern University	50	23	20
24	Ohio State University	49	23	18
25	Federal Reserve System	48	22	18
26	University of Arizona	46	24	17
27	UCLA	46	27	18
28	Columbia University	45	31	18
29	Duke University	44	34	18
30	Carnegie Mellon University	42	27	13

Notes: Ranking is by total presentations. Schools (Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Chicago Booth, Kellogg, Wharton, Sloan, Haas, etc.) are rolled up into their parent university. Presenters listing two affiliations joined by "and" contribute to both. Research-affiliate networks (NBER, CEPR, IZA) are not counted as standalone employers. *Distinct Presenters* is the number of unique individuals from that institution; *Years* is the number of conference editions with at least one presenter from it.

reversal that tracks the shifting center of gravity of IO research more broadly.

The share of female presenters (among those with classifiable names) has hovered around 21% for most of the sample period, with a modest increase to 26% by 2026 (Figure 8). This is in line with Lundberg and Stearns (2019)'s "stalled progress" narrative for women in

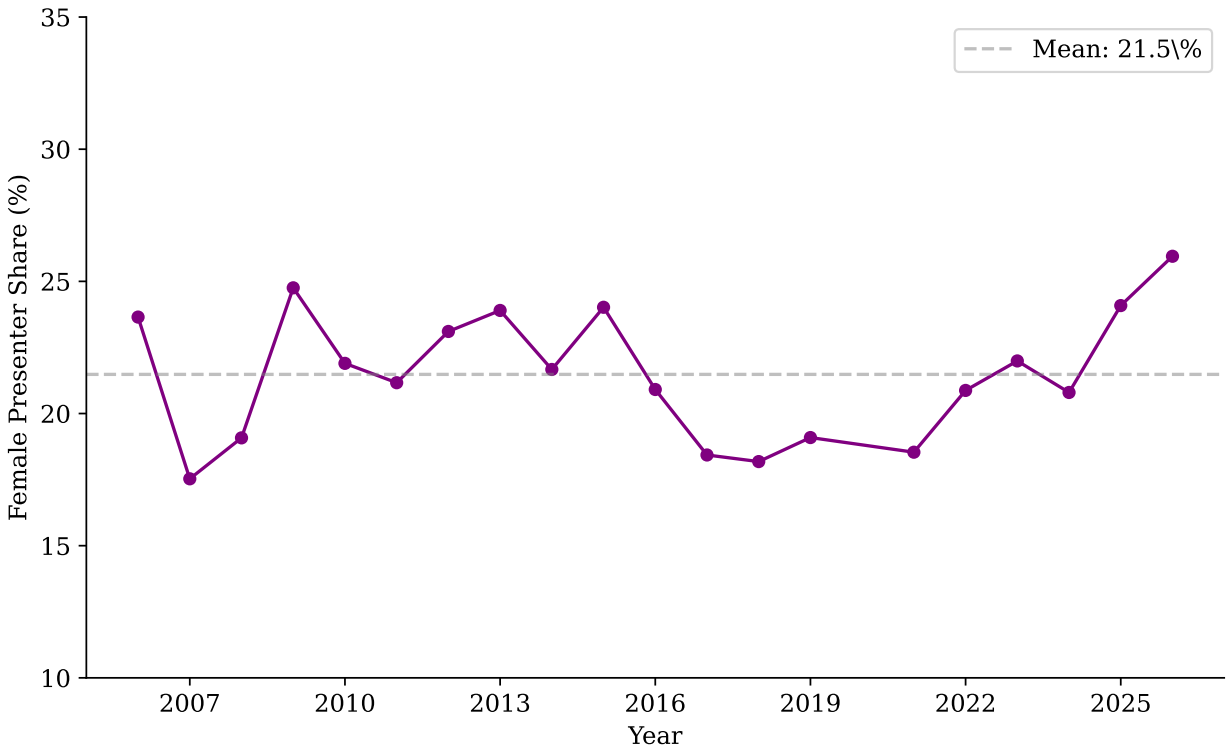
Figure 7: Geographic Origin of IIOC Presenters Over Time



Notes: Regional shares are computed as a percentage of all presentations each year. North America (not shown) accounts for the residual, typically 75–80%. The Asia-Pacific category includes East Asian, Australasian, Israeli, and Turkish institutions; the regions are assigned via keyword matching against institution names.

economics and with the broader conference evidence of Hospido and Sanz (2021) and Dupas et al. (2026). Two features of the IIOC nonetheless stand out. First, Rising Star sessions consistently feature a higher female share (28% versus 21% in regular sessions), suggesting that either the selection process for these sessions is more gender-balanced or that the pipeline of junior women in IO is stronger than the stock of senior researchers would suggest. Second, the data offer no evidence of deterioration: the trend, however modest, is upward.

Figure 8: Female Presenter Share Over Time

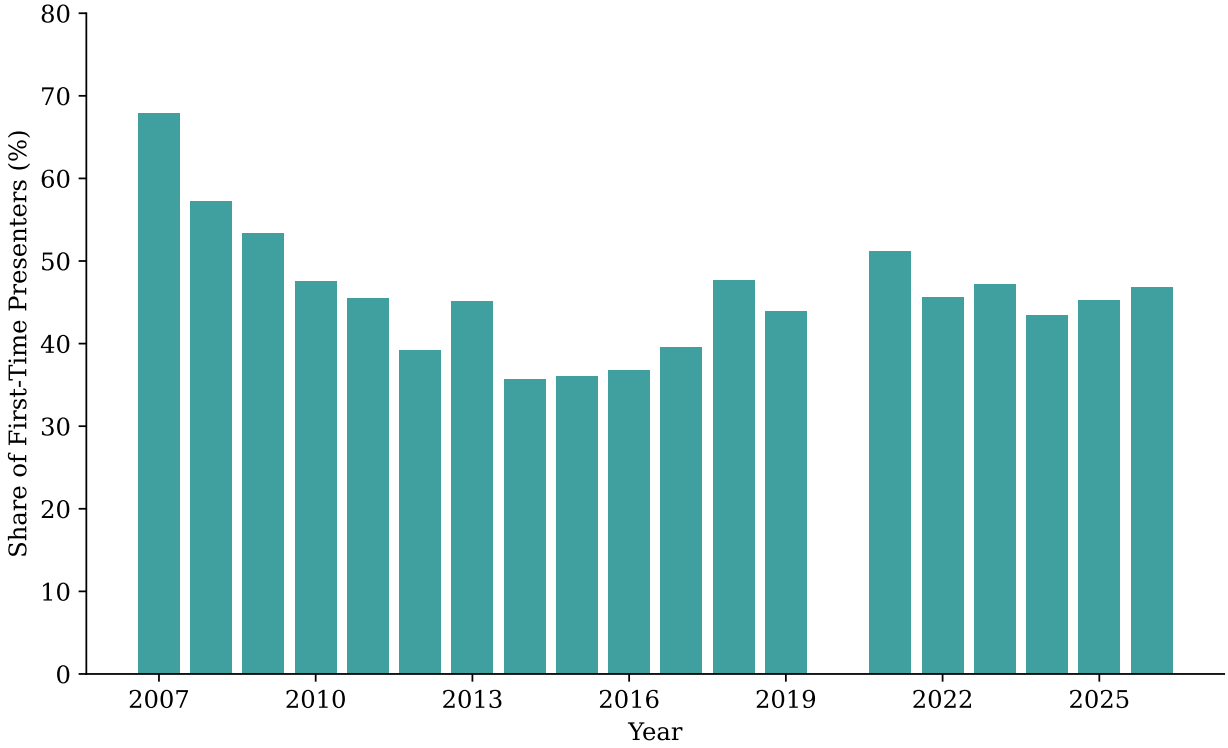


Notes: The female share is computed among presenters with classifiable first names (approximately 78% of the sample); presenters with unclassifiable or ambiguous first names (predominantly East Asian names and initials) are excluded from both the numerator and the denominator. The dashed line shows the sample mean.

3.4 Returning Presenters and Seniority

The conference has a stable core of regular attendees alongside substantial turnover. About 55% of all presenters appear exactly once: they present a paper and never return. Another 30% appear two or three times, and the remaining 15% present four or more times, forming the community's backbone. In any given year, about 40–45% of presenters are appearing at the IIOC for the first time (Figure 9), indicating healthy inflow of new researchers even as the conference shrinks.

Figure 9: Share of First-Time Presenters, by Conference Year



Notes: For each year after 2006, I compute the share of presenters whose name does not appear in any earlier IIOC program. The 2006 edition is excluded because all presenters are mechanically "first-time" in the sample. The share stabilizes in the 40–50% range after the first few years.

Tables 3 and 4 list the 30 most frequent presenters and the top 20 overall regulars (counting presenter and discussant roles together). Christopher Snyder of Dartmouth College holds the record, with 22 presentations across 20 of the 21 years; when discussant roles are added, his total rises to 44 appearances, followed by Jordi Jaumandreu and Ginger Jin.

Table 3: Top 30 Presenters at IIOC, 2006–2026

	Presenter	Pres.	Yrs	Latest Institution
1	Christopher Snyder	21	19	Dartmouth College
2	Ginger Jin	18	13	University of Maryland at College P
3	Alexei Alexandrov	15	11	Unaffiliated for research purposes
4	Dongsoo Shin	15	14	Santa Clara University
5	Qihong Liu	15	12	University of Oklahoma
6	Jordi Jaumandreu	15	14	Boston University
7	Dakshina De Silva	14	13	Lancaster University
8	Lawrence White	14	11	Stern School of Business, New York
9	Konstantinos Serfes	13	13	Drexel University
10	Ting Liu	13	12	Stony Brook University
11	Teresa Harrison	13	12	Drexel University
12	Georgia Kosmopoulou	13	13	University of Oklahoma
13	Matthijs Wildenbeest	13	12	University of Arizona
14	Federico Ciliberto	12	9	U Virginia
15	Emek Basker	12	12	U.S. Census Bureau
16	Robert Feinberg	12	12	American University
17	Jeffrey Prince	12	11	Kelley School of Business, Indiana
18	Nathan Wilson	12	10	Compass Lexecon
19	Andras Niedermayer	12	10	University of Mannheim
20	Peter Newberry	12	12	University of Georgia
21	Ching-I Huang	12	11	National Taiwan University
22	Thomas Jeitschko	12	10	Michigan State University
23	Yossi Spiegel	12	10	Tel Aviv University
24	Timothy Brennan	11	7	University of Maryland Baltimore Co
25	Chun-Yu Ho	11	11	University at Albany, SUNY
26	Devesh Raval	11	10	Federal Trade Commission
27	Andrea Mantovani	11	10	TSE
28	Michael Ward	11	9	University of Texas at Arlington
29	Haizhen Lin	11	10	Indiana University
30	Andrew Toole	11	9	US Patent and Trademark Office

Notes: *Pres.* is the total number of IIOC presentations; *Yrs* is the number of distinct conference years in which the individual appeared as a presenter. The institution listed is the affiliation recorded at the individual's most recent IIOC appearance.

Beyond the distinction between one-timers and regulars, a more substantive question is whether the *seniority* of the typical presenter has changed over time. Using the author profiles built from the OpenAlex economics works database, I match 71% of presenter-year

Table 4: Top 30 IIOC Regulars (Presenter or Discussant Appearances)

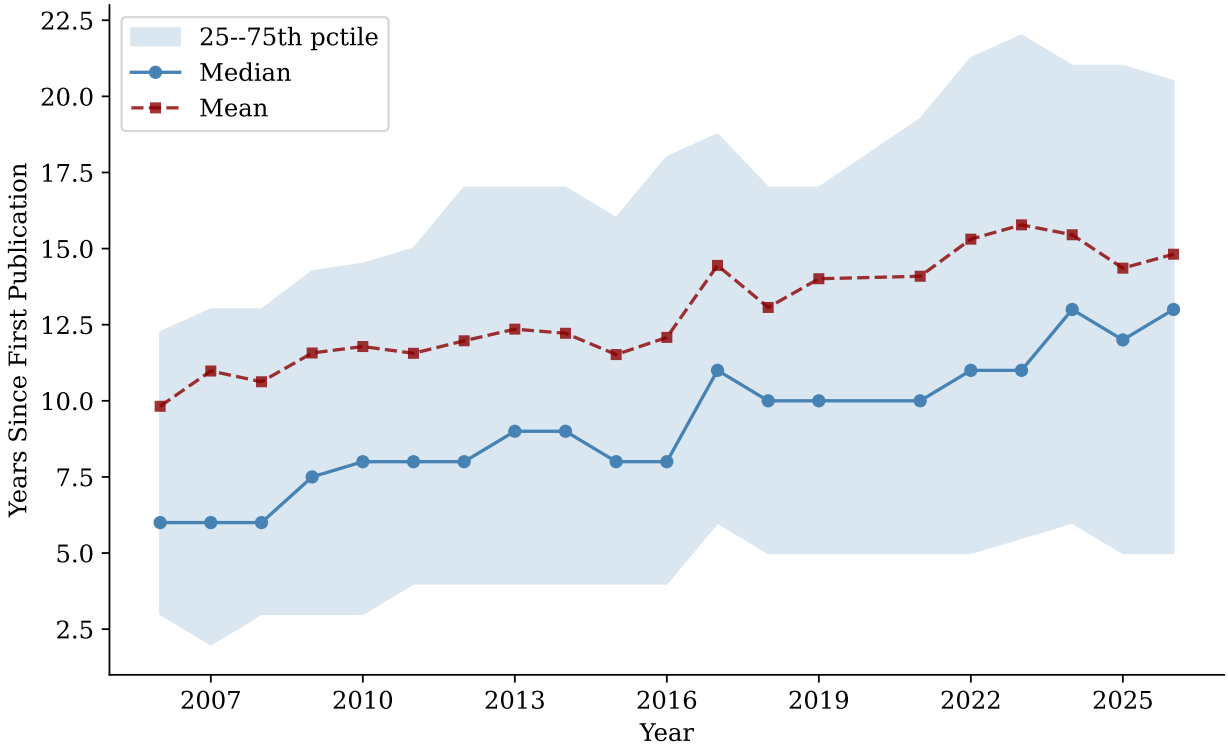
	Name	Total	Presenter	Discussant
1	Christopher Snyder	43	21	22
2	Jordi Jaumandreu	34	15	19
3	Ginger Jin	33	18	15
4	Qihong Liu	32	15	17
5	Dongsoo Shin	30	15	15
6	Alexei Alexandrov	29	15	14
7	Emek Basker	28	12	16
8	Jeffrey Prince	28	12	16
9	Matthijs Wildenbeest	28	13	15
10	Georgia Kosmopoulou	28	13	15
11	Teresa Harrison	27	13	14
12	Nathan Wilson	27	12	15
13	Peter Newberry	27	12	15
14	Konstantinos Serfes	26	13	13
15	Dakshina De Silva	26	14	12
16	Robert Feinberg	26	12	14
17	Devesh Raval	26	11	15
18	Federico Ciliberto	25	12	13
19	Matthew Lewis	25	10	15
20	Haizhen Lin	25	11	14
21	Christopher Conlon	25	10	15
22	Thomas Jeitschko	24	12	12
23	Michael Ward	24	11	13
24	Bettina Peters	24	11	13
25	Ting Liu	24	13	11
26	Marc Rysman	23	8	15
27	Yossi Spiegel	23	12	11
28	Lawrence White	23	14	9
29	Ching-I Huang	23	12	11
30	Jonathan Williams	23	9	14

Notes: Ranking is by total appearances across both roles. A discussant appears formally on the program even if the individual is not also presenting, and vice versa.

observations to a first-publication year and define seniority as the difference between the conference year and the presenter's earliest recorded journal article. Figure 10 plots the distribution year by year.

The change is large. The median presenter's years of publishing experience rose from 6 in 2006 to 13 in 2026, more than a doubling. The mean rose from 10 to 15 years. Both the 25th and 75th percentile shifted right by comparable amounts, so the pattern is not being driven by a small number of very senior researchers dragging the mean; the whole distribution has moved. Combined with the concentration and RePEc top-20 results above, the picture is of

Figure 10: Seniority of IIOC Presenters Over Time



Notes: Seniority is measured as the conference year minus the presenter's first-publication year in the OpenAlex economics works database. Observations with unmatched or implausible first-publication years are dropped, leaving 71% of presentations. The shaded band is the 25th-to-75th percentile range; the solid line is the median; the dashed line is the mean.

a conference whose typical presenter is drawn from a more senior and more prestigious pool than two decades ago.

One natural confound is that the economics profession as a whole has become older (Hamermesh, 2013). But the magnitude observed here, a 7-year increase in median seniority over 20 years, exceeds what profession-wide aging alone can plausibly produce over the same period. The IIOC appears to have specifically moved upmarket: more senior presenters from more concentrated institutions, with fewer of the newer, fringe affiliations that populated the 2006–2010 programs.

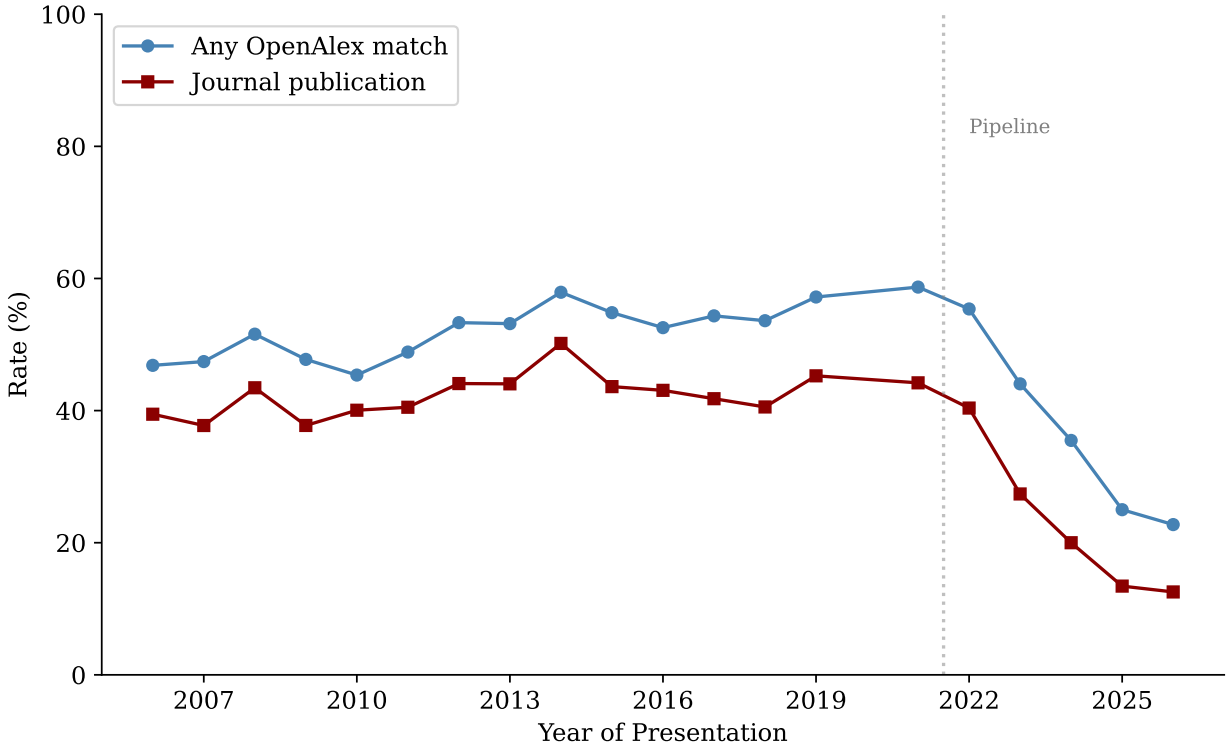
4 From Presentation to Publication

A central question about any academic conference is how effectively it serves as a pipeline to publication. Using the matched OpenAlex data, I can track publication outcomes for IIOC presentations with reasonable coverage. The matching is intentionally conservative: I would rather under-count true publications than inflate the journal rate with noisy matches between same-named authors or loose title overlap. The 2020 conference was cancelled due to COVID-19 and is omitted from all pipeline statistics.

For the mature cohorts (presentations from 2006 through 2021, which have had at least five years to move through the publication process), about 40% are verifiably matched to a peer-reviewed journal publication (Figure 11). The matching is deliberately conservative and uses four gates: (i) an IIOC presenter or coauthor must appear as an author on the candidate publication; (ii) the candidate outlet must be in an economics, business, social-science or decision-science field (medical, physics, engineering and conference-proceedings outlets are all rejected); (iii) the IIOC paper title and the journal paper title must either share a character-level Levenshtein similarity above 0.65 or share at least two substantive content words with a token-set similarity above 0.45; (iv) an automated audit flags and clears known false-positive patterns (shared-surname disambiguation failures, title drift that is too loose). The 40% figure is therefore a lower bound on the true publication rate: some genuine matches are missed when both the title and the coauthor list change substantially between conference and journal. The 2022–2026 cohorts show mechanically lower rates because many papers remain under review; this is what Ellison (2002) calls the "long tail" of the publication process.

The 40% journal publication rate is at the lower end of the 40–50% benchmark estimated by Spiegel and Toivanen (2022) for the EARIE conference; differences in matching methodology make direct comparisons tentative, but the order of magnitude lines up. Both estimates imply that a substantial majority of IIOC presentations do eventually reach a refereed outlet,

Figure 11: From IIOC Presentation to Publication



Notes: The upper series ("Any OpenAlex match") includes working-paper repositories; the lower series ("Journal publication") counts only peer-reviewed journal articles. Vertical line marks the boundary between mature cohorts (2006–2021) and the publication pipeline (2022–2026), where many papers are still in review and the gap between the two series is mechanically wider.

consistent with the broader pattern for field conferences in economics documented by **?**. The gap between the any-match rate (around 52%) and the journal rate (around 40%) captures papers that are posted as NBER, SSRN, or similar working papers but do not receive a separate journal publication within the observation window.

Table 5 reports the 30 leading outlets after canonicalizing journal names (so that "The RAND Journal of Economics" and "RAND Journal of Economics" count together, and the HTML-entity variant of the JEMS title collapses with the plain-text version). The field's flagship, the *International Journal of Industrial Organization*, leads with 210 matched papers, followed by the *RAND Journal of Economics* (130), the *Journal of Industrial Economics* (106), *Management Science* (85), and *AEJ: Microeconomics* (82). Of the top-5 general-interest journals, the *American Economic Review* accounts for 63 papers, *Journal of Political Economy* for 55, and *Review of Economic Studies* for 44; together, the top-5 outlets account for roughly 3–4% of all IIOC papers, a small share in absolute terms but notable given the selectivity of these outlets. Figure 12 visualizes the distribution.

Figure 12: Top 15 Journal Outlets for IIOC Papers

Notes: Horizontal bars show the top 15 peer-reviewed journal outlets by number of IIOC-presented papers matched in OpenAlex. Working-paper series (NBER, SSRN, RePEc, arXiv) are excluded.

The citation distribution among published IIOC papers is heavily right-skewed (Figure 13). The median published paper has a modest citation count, while a small number of

Table 5: Top 30 Journal Outlets for IIOC Papers

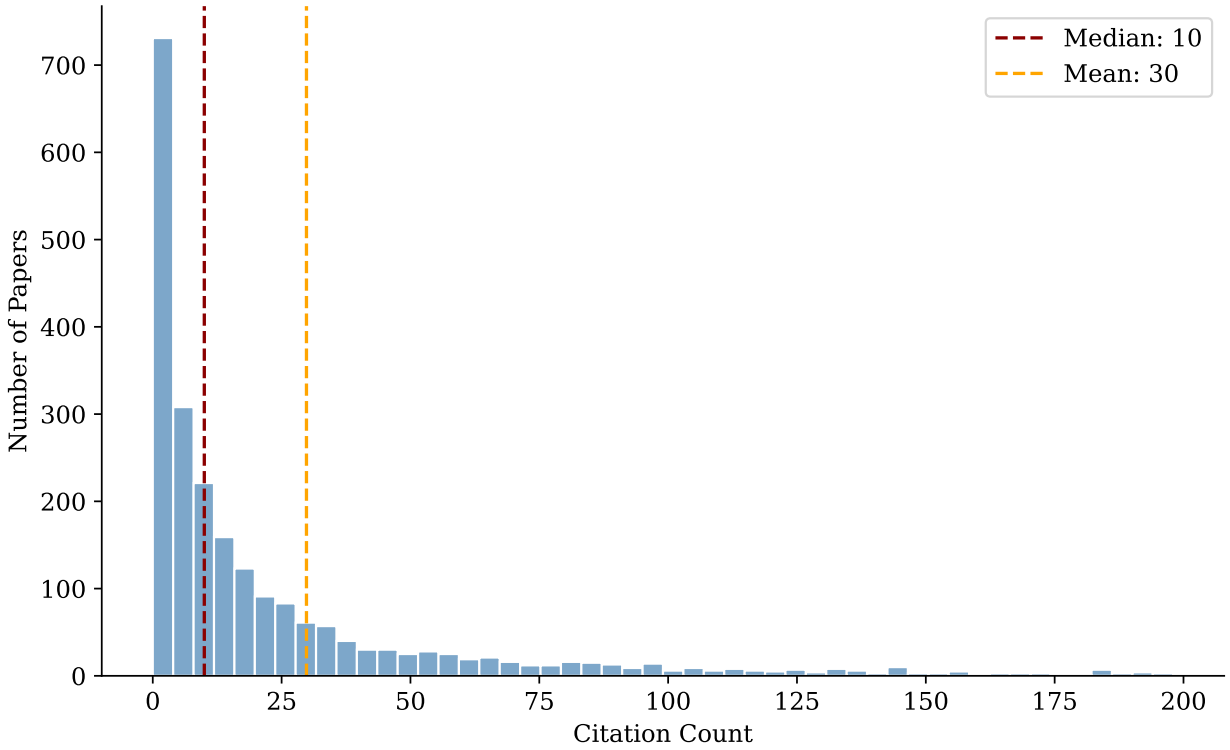
	Journal	Papers
1	International Journal of Industrial Organization	210
2	RAND Journal of Economics	130
3	Journal of Industrial Economics	106
4	Management Science	85
5	American Economic Journal: Microeconomics	82
6	Journal of Economics & Management Strategy	77
7	Review of Industrial Organization	63
8	American Economic Review	63
9	Journal of Political Economy	55
10	Review of Economic Studies	44
11	Marketing Science	41
12	Review of Economics and Statistics	40
13	Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization	36
14	International Economic Review	34
15	Economics Letters	32
16	Economic Inquiry	29
17	European Economic Review	28
18	Journal of Law and Economics	27
19	American Economic Journal: Economic Policy	27
20	Quantitative Marketing and Economics	26
21	Economic Journal	25
22	Information Economics and Policy	24
23	Journal of Health Economics	22
24	Journal of Economic Theory	21
25	Journal of Regulatory Economics	19
26	Games and Economic Behavior	19
27	Econometrica	18
28	Review of Network Economics	17
29	Research Policy	16
30	Journal of Econometrics	16

Notes: Ranking by number of IIOC-presented papers matched to each journal in OpenAlex. Working-paper series (NBER, SSRN, RePEc, arXiv, preprint repositories) are excluded from the count. Journal titles are canonicalized (leading "The" stripped, HTML entities fixed) so that, e.g., "Journal of Industrial Economics" and "The Journal of Industrial Economics" count together.

highly cited papers pull the mean well above the median, the familiar pattern of academic impact documented by Hamermesh (2013) and many others.

A more pointed version of the publication question is not *whether* IIOC papers get published but *where*. Figure 14 classifies every IIOC paper by the tier of its eventual publication outlet, from top-5 general-interest journals at the top to unmatched papers at the bottom. The tiers used here follow the RePEc journal ranking and group the *American Economic*

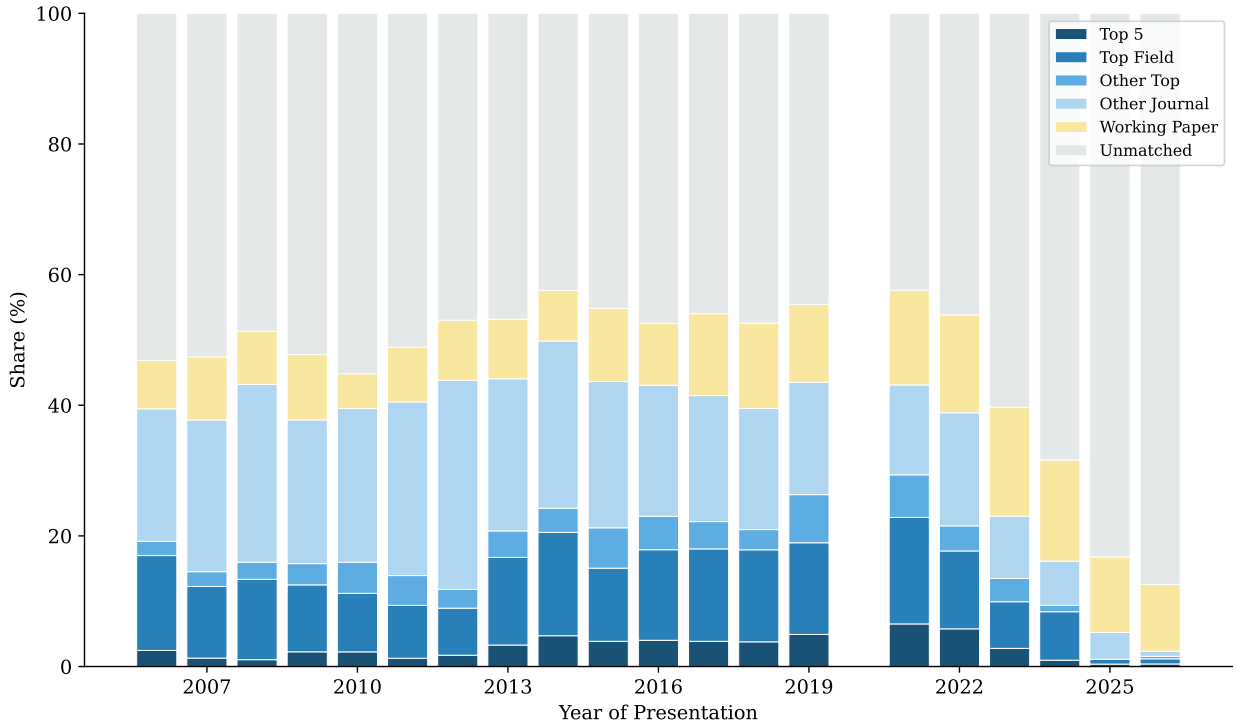
Figure 13: Citation Distribution of Published IIOC Papers



Notes: Histogram of OpenAlex citation counts for IIOC papers that were matched to a peer-reviewed journal publication. The x-axis is censored at 200 citations for readability; a long right tail extends beyond. Vertical lines mark the median and mean.

Review, *Econometrica*, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *Journal of Political Economy*, and *Review of Economic Studies* as the top-5 tier; field journals are split into a "top-field" tier (*International Journal of Industrial Organization*, *RAND Journal of Economics*, *Journal of Industrial Economics*, *Management Science*, and the AEJ series) and a broader "field" tier for the remainder.

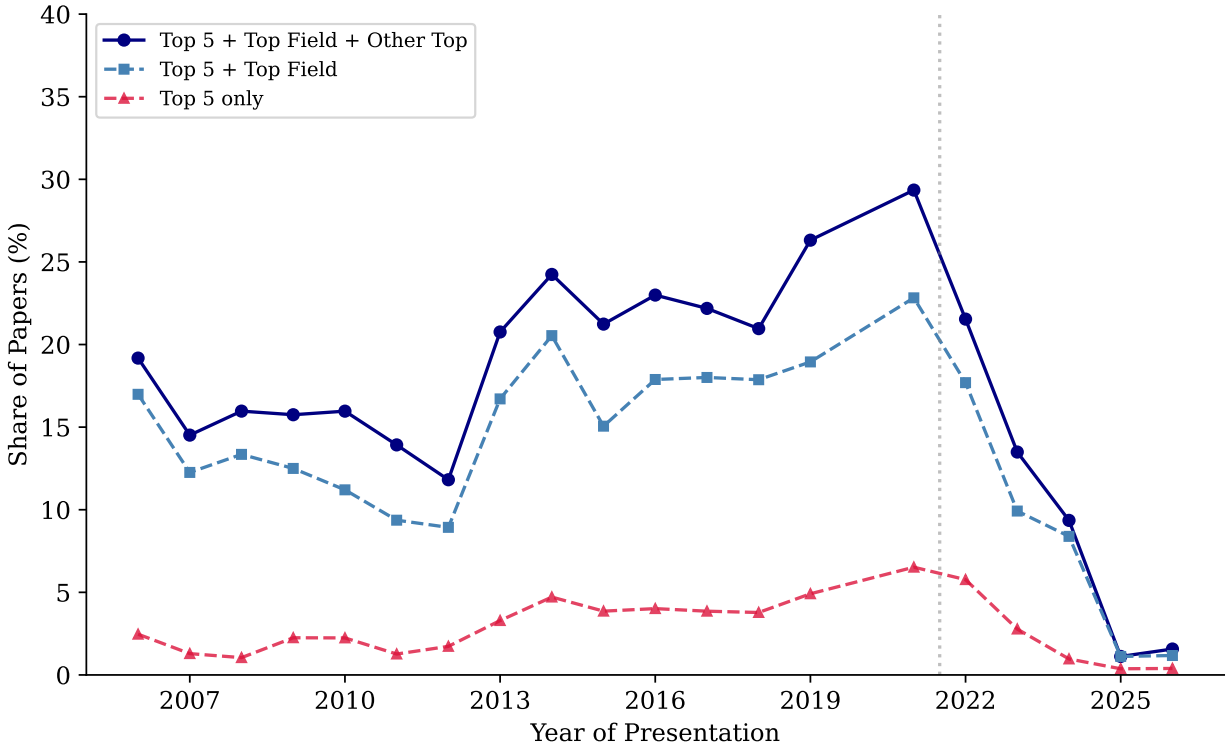
Figure 14: Publication Outcomes by Journal Tier, 2006–2026



Notes: Each bar shows the distribution of a cohort's papers across six mutually exclusive outcome tiers. Top 5: AER, Econometrica, JPE, QJE, REStud. Top Field: RAND, IJIO, JIE, AEJ Micro, JEMS, Management Science, Marketing Science, QME. Other Top: REStat, JHE, JLE, EER, IER, JEEA, EJ, JF, JFE, RFS, JDE, AEJ EP. The 2022–2026 cohorts have elevated "Unmatched" shares because many papers remain in review.

The picture is striking. The share of IIOC papers eventually published in top-5 journals has nearly tripled, from 1.2% in 2006–2010 to 3.1% in 2016–2021 (Figure 15). The combined share in top-5 plus top field journals rose from 9.6% to 13.4% over the same period. This pattern is consistent with the concentration, RePEc top-20, and seniority results above: as the conference shrank and the presenter pool moved upmarket, the average paper's publication ceiling rose as well. Card and DellaVigna (2013) document that top-5 acceptance rates have been declining and slots becoming scarcer, so the rising top-5 share at the IIOC cannot reflect profession-wide slackness; it appears to be specific to the IIOC's changing composition.

Figure 15: Share of IIOC Papers Published in Top Journals



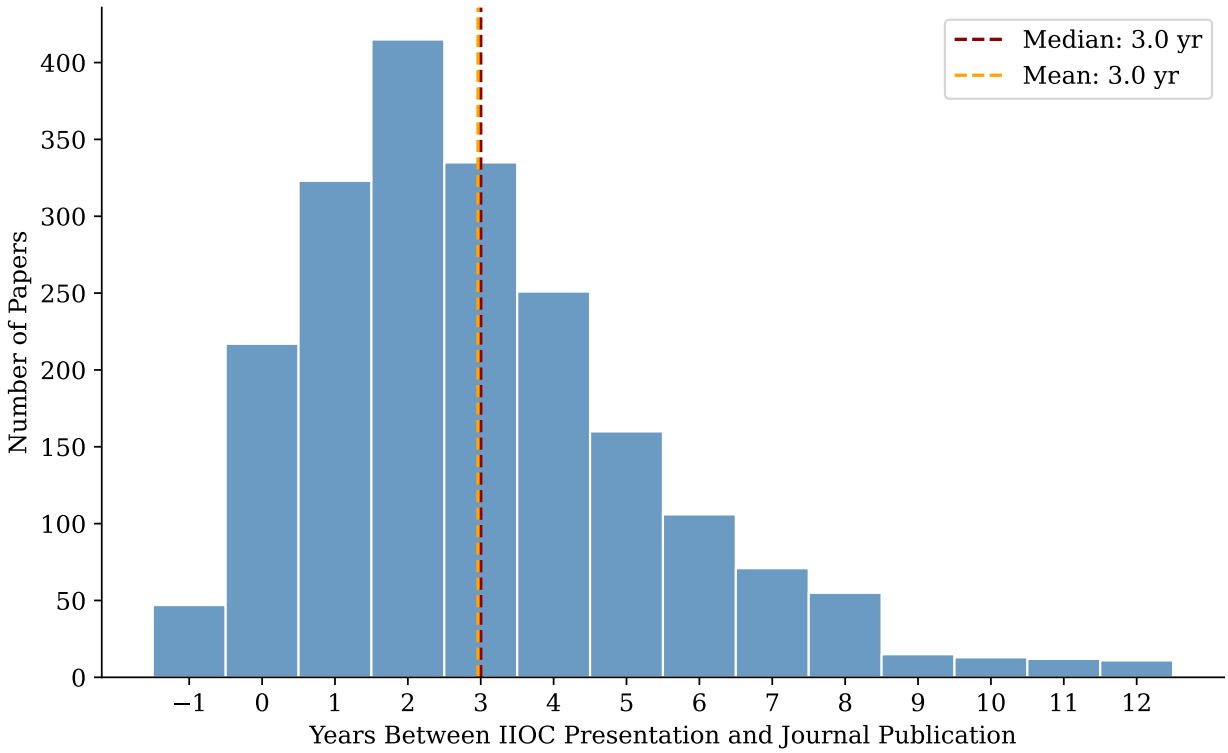
Notes: Three series, all computed on a cohort basis. The top-5 only series shows the share of each year's IIOC papers that appeared in AER, Econometrica, JPE, QJE, or REStud. The top-5 + top-field series adds the top IO and business-school outlets (see Figure 14 notes). The most inclusive series adds a set of other leading general-interest and field journals.

4.1 How Long Does It Take?

A complementary question is not *whether* an IIOC paper gets published but *when*. For every paper matched to a peer-reviewed journal publication, I compute the lag in years between the IIOC presentation date and the journal's publication year. Restricting to the mature cohort (presentations from 2006 through 2021) and to lags of 12 years or less leaves 2,782 papers with a clean lag measurement.

The median lag is 2 years and the mean is 2.6, with an interquartile range of roughly 0 to 4 years (Figure 16). The distribution has two notable features. First, the mode at zero and one year: a non-trivial share of IIOC papers appear in print within a year of being presented, which typically means the paper was already accepted or close to acceptance when it was presented. Second, a long right tail: 10% of matched papers take six or more years between presentation and publication, consistent with Ellison (2002)'s description of the "long tail" of economics publishing.

Figure 16: Distribution of Lag Between IIOC Presentation and Journal Publication

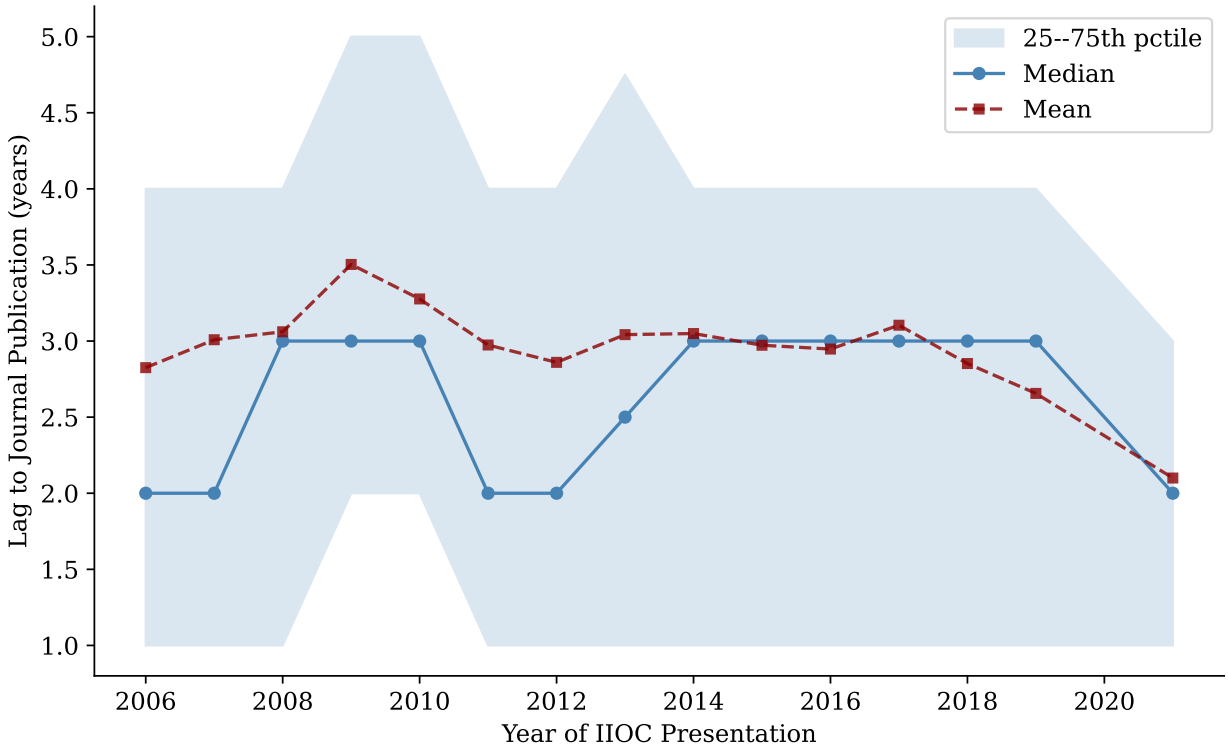


Notes: Histogram of the difference between the journal's publication year and the IIOC presentation year for matched mature-cohort papers (2006–2021). Lags below −1 or above 12 years are excluded as match noise; this leaves 2,782 papers. Vertical lines indicate the median and mean.

Has the lag changed over two decades? Figure 17 plots the median and mean lag by IIOC cohort year. Both series are remarkably flat: the median has held at 2 years in almost

every cohort, and the mean fluctuates narrowly around 2.5. This is a mild surprise. Ellison (2002) documented a marked slowdown in economics publishing through the early 2000s, and Spiegel and Toivanen (2022) estimate average lags above three years at EARIE. The stability of the IIOC lag over twenty years suggests that once a paper is in the conference pipeline, the time to publication has not meaningfully lengthened, even as the conference itself has contracted and shifted upmarket.

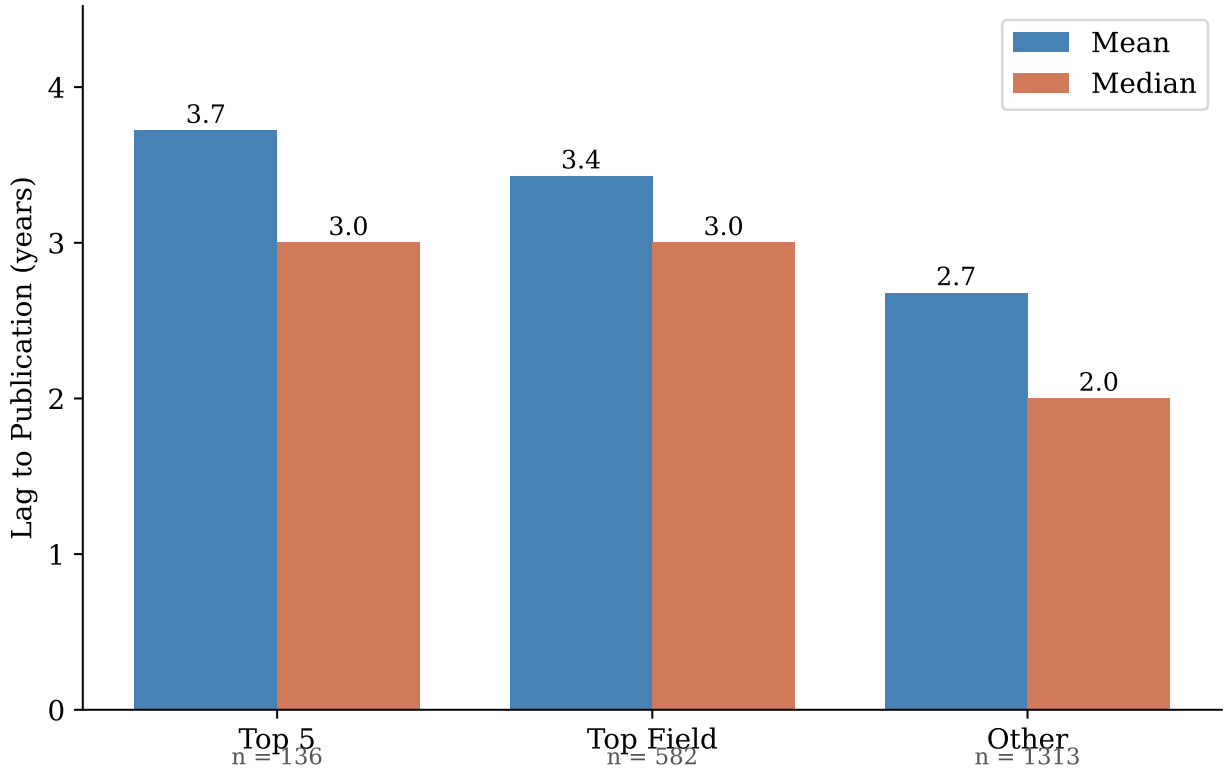
Figure 17: Publication Lag by IIOC Cohort Year



Notes: For each IIOC cohort 2006–2021 (excluding 2020), the plot shows the median lag to journal publication and the 25th–75th percentile band. Cohorts with fewer than 20 journal matches are dropped for stability. Cohorts after 2021 are omitted because many papers are still in review and the measured lag would be downward-biased.

A useful disaggregation is by journal tier, since top journals typically run longer review rounds and the "mode-at-zero" papers are disproportionately field-journal placements. Figure 18 summarises the mean and median lag for each tier on the mature cohort. Top-5 and top-field journals carry essentially the same lag (mean 2.9, median 3 years); other journals sit roughly half a year lower (mean 2.5, median 2). Placing in a top outlet adds about five to six months of review time relative to the median IIOC paper, but the premium journals do not separate from each other.

Figure 18: Publication Lag by Journal Tier (Mature Cohort, 2006–2021)



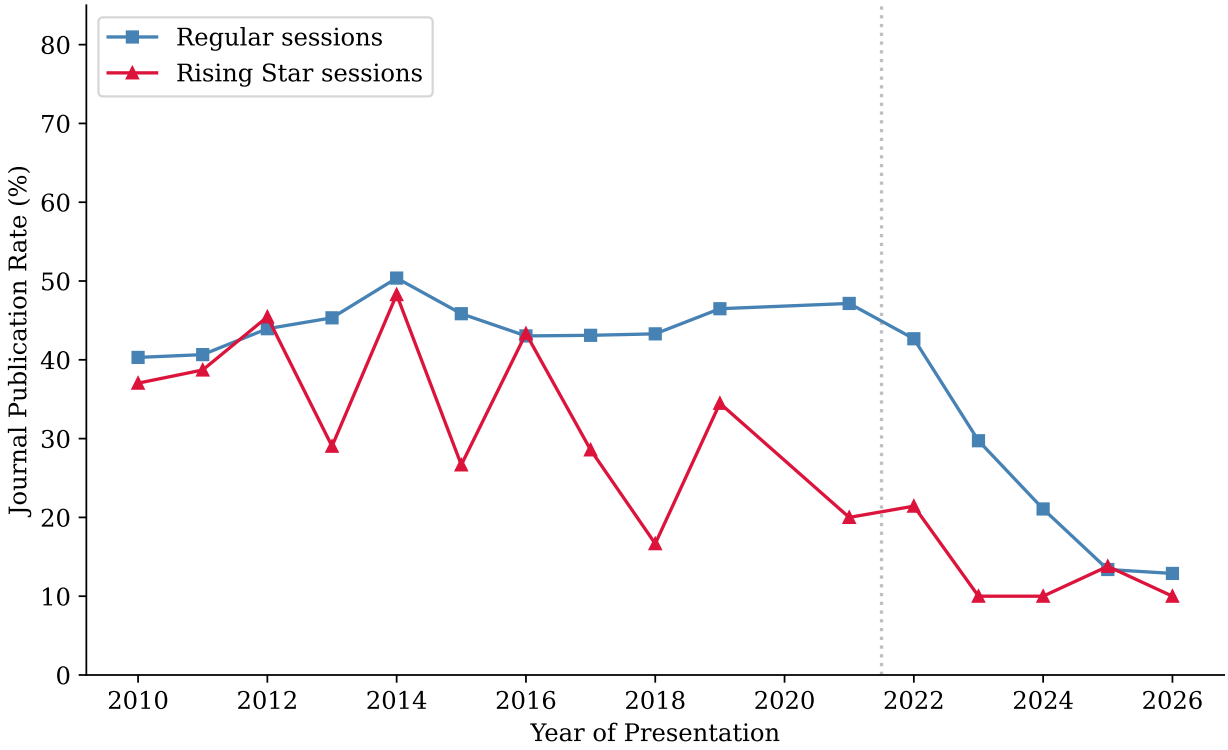
Notes: Mean and median lag in years between IIOC presentation and journal publication, computed on the mature cohort (2006–2021 presentations). Tier definitions follow Figure 14. Sample sizes are shown below each pair of bars.

5 Rising Stars

The Rising Star sessions, sponsored by the Alfred P. Sloan Foundation, were introduced in 2010 to showcase promising early-career researchers. These sessions have become a fixed feature of the conference, accounting for approximately 30 papers per year (about 10 sessions of 3 papers each, all scheduled in the first evening time slot).

Rising Star presenters differ from regular presenters in measurable ways. They are more likely to be female (28% versus 21%, among classifiable names) and, by construction, are at an earlier career stage. Their journal publication rate for mature cohorts (2010–2021) is 58%, compared with 62% for regular session papers (Figure 19). The modest gap likely reflects the earlier developmental stage of Rising Star papers at the time of presentation rather than lower ultimate quality: these are working papers by junior researchers who have not yet had as many rounds of revision and resubmission as their more senior peers presenting in regular sessions.

Figure 19: Journal Publication Rates: Rising Stars vs. Regular Sessions



Notes: Annual journal publication rates are shown separately for papers in Rising Star sessions and in regular sessions, starting in 2010 (the first year of the Rising Star program). The vertical line marks the boundary between mature and pipeline cohorts.

6 Does the Discussant Matter?

Each IIOC paper is assigned a discussant, a fellow researcher who reads the paper, provides formal comments during the session, and ideally offers constructive feedback that improves the final product. A natural question is whether the quality of the discussant predicts the paper's publication outcome. If higher-quality discussants provide more valuable feedback, we might expect their papers to fare better. Since 2006 the IIOC has additionally designated Rising Star sessions specifically to pair junior presenters with senior discussants, which should bias any discussant-quality effect upward in the raw data; the analysis below therefore conditions on year fixed effects throughout.

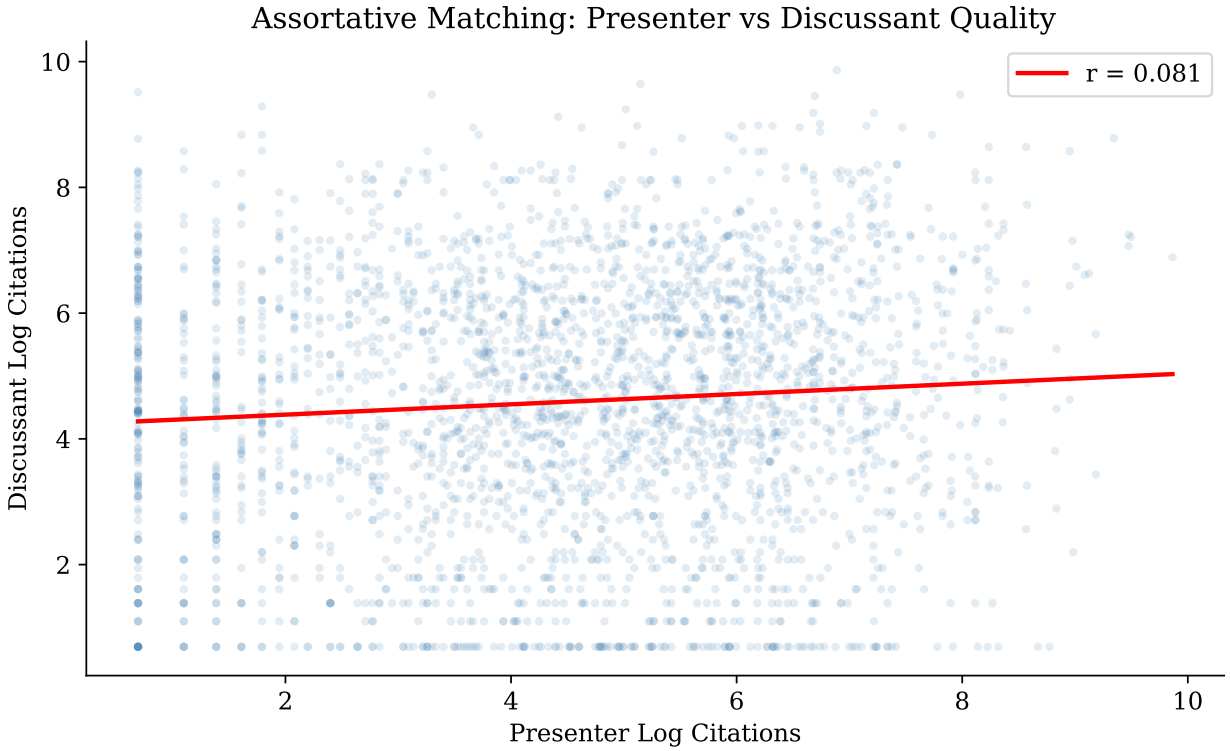
I construct citation profiles for all presenters and discussants by extracting author-level publication and citation statistics from the OpenAlex economics works database. This yields profiles for 86% of presenters and 79% of discussants in the IIOC data. The coverage gap arises from a combination of name ambiguity (common surnames that match several OpenAlex entities) and a handful of non-academic discussants from industry and regulatory agencies whose publication records are sparse. The remaining sample is large enough that within-year comparisons of citation rank are well identified.

The first question is whether presenter and discussant quality are correlated, that is, whether the conference engages in assortative matching. The evidence suggests it does, but only weakly. The Spearman rank correlation between presenter and discussant total citations is 0.081 ($p < 0.001$). Presenters in the top quintile of citations receive discussants with a median of 149 citations, compared with 88 for bottom-quintile presenters (Figure 20). The matching is thus mildly assortative rather than random, but far from deterministic.

The more consequential question is whether discussant quality predicts publication outcomes. Here the answer is clearly no. Journal publication rates are essentially flat across discussant quality quintiles, ranging from 61.3% to 63.1% with no monotonic trend (Figure 21). A linear probability model regressing publication status on log presenter citations, log discussant citations, and year fixed effects confirms this null: the presenter's own citation record modestly predicts publication ($\beta = 0.007$, $t = 2.06$), but the discussant's citations have no predictive power ($\beta = -0.004$, $t = -0.79$).

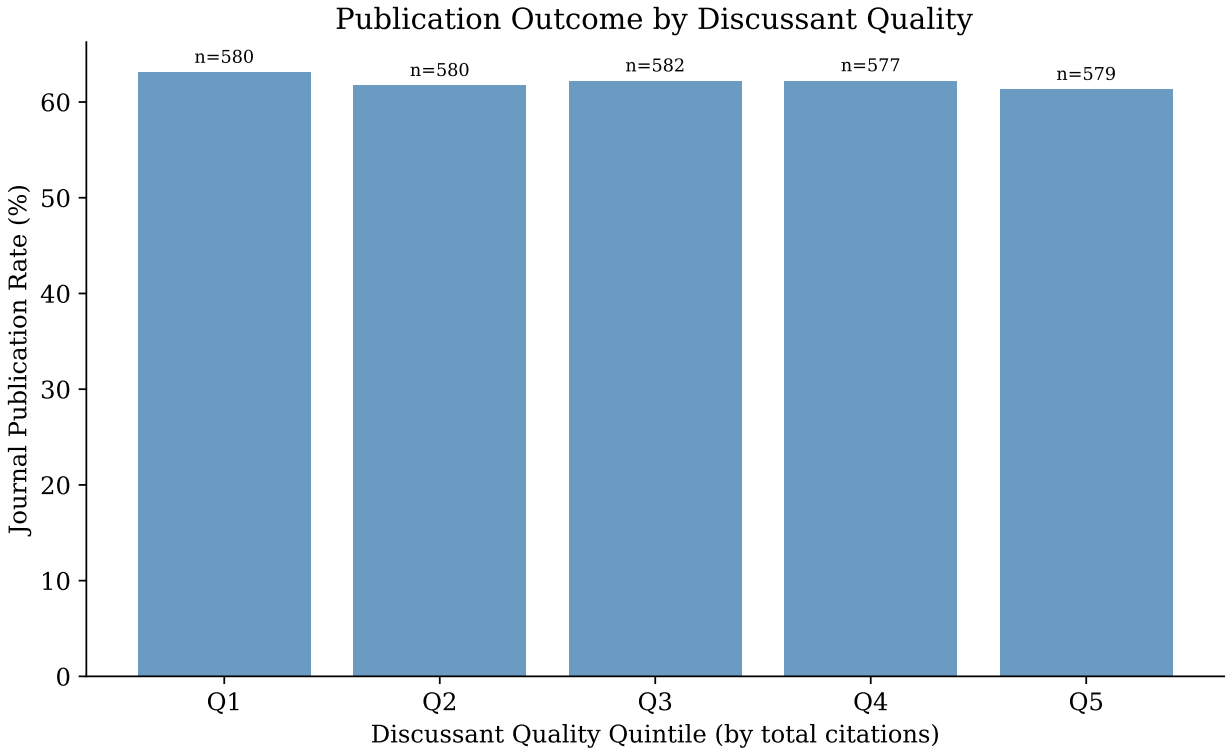
This null has two natural interpretations. The optimistic reading is that the conference allocates discussants roughly equitably, and that all discussants, regardless of seniority, provide equally useful feedback. The pessimistic reading is that formal discussant comments at conferences have little impact on a paper's trajectory relative to other inputs (referee reports, seminar feedback, coauthor effort). Either way, the data offer no support for the hypothesis that getting a "star" discussant improves a paper's publication prospects.

Figure 20: Assortative Matching: Presenter vs. Discussant Quality



Notes: Each point is one IIOC paper. Axes show the natural logarithm of each individual's total career citations in OpenAlex. The red line is the OLS fit; the slope corresponds to a Pearson correlation of 0.081 on log-citation units.

Figure 21: Publication Outcome by Discussant Quality Quintile



Notes: Discussants are sorted into quintiles by their OpenAlex total-citation count. The bars show the share of papers in each quintile that were subsequently matched to a peer-reviewed journal publication. The variation across quintiles is economically small (about 2 percentage points) and not statistically different from zero in a linear probability model with year fixed effects.

7 Conclusion

This paper provides a comprehensive empirical portrait of the IIOC over its 21-year history from 2006 to 2026. Five facts stand out. First, the conference has become smaller, falling from 400 to 254 papers per year, through a reduction in parallel sessions rather than a shorter schedule. Second, institutional concentration has risen on both ends: the HHI of presenting institutions has nearly doubled, and the share of presentations from RePEc top-20 departments has risen from 16% to 25%. Third, the typical presenter has become substantially more senior, with median years of publishing experience doubling from 6 to 13. Fourth, Asia-Pacific representation has more than doubled while European representation has declined. Fifth, the share of IIOC papers placing in top-5 general-interest journals has nearly tripled. The combined picture is one of a conference that has moved upmarket: smaller, more senior, more concentrated at the top, and producing a higher share of top-journal output. A formal test of whether discussant quality matters for publication yields a precise null.

The dataset constructed here, covering 6,613 presentations matched to bibliometric outcomes together with presenter and discussant citation profiles, may prove useful for further research on the dynamics of academic knowledge production in industrial organization. Natural extensions include tracking the career trajectories of individual Rising Star presenters, comparing the IIOC's patterns with those of EARIE and APIOC as comparable regional pillars, and examining whether the upmarket drift documented here is specific to IO or reflects a broader move among economics field conferences.

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